



worldwide today. The largest communities are in Romania, Bulgaria, and Hungary, but there are Roma throughout Europe as well as North America and Australia. The Roma

people originated in northern India. They left India in the 11th century in search of a better life, reaching Europe a couple of centuries later. Prejudice against them persists, although most are now settled.

A LOVE OF MUSIC

Because they valued the freedom to travel, Roma chose professions that they could practice wherever they found themselves. They became famous for their music. Roma musicians have contributed to Hungarian and Spanish music, particularly the Spanish *flamenco* style.



Most of the would-be brides are still in their teens.

A ROMA CELEBRATION

An international Gypsy Festival is held every May in the Czech Republic. Roma dancers and musicians from as far as Brazil, Russia, and Egypt attend the festival, which features concerts, performances, discussions, and a parade through the city's streets.

The festival shows how Roma performers have contributed to the cultural life of the countries they live in.

LOOKING FOR LOVE

The groom traditionally pays the bride's family for the right to marry her. Every year, a fair is held in the Bulgarian town of Stara Zagora at which families decide who their daughters will marry. The girls wear their finest clothes for the occasion.

